

Field Work Documentation

Traditional Handicraft Clusters of Tamil Nadu: Decline, Challenges and Revival Interventions

This documentation compiles field-level observations and statistical data for four Geographical Indication (GI)-tagged traditional handicraft clusters of Tamil Nadu studied as part of this project: Toda Tribal Embroidery (The Nilgiris), Pattamadai Korai Grass Mats (Tirunelveli), Bronze Casting / Thanjavur Art (Thanjavur), and Bhavani Jamakkalam Weaving (Erode). A separate paragraph is given below for each field work location, covering the statistical scale of the artisan base, the specific challenges threatening the craft's survival, and the improvements or interventions required or already underway to sustain livelihoods.

1. The Nilgiris District (Ooty / Tribal Belts) — Toda Tribal Embroidery

Field interaction with Toda women embroiderers in the Nilgiri mounds around Ooty shows a craft that is culturally central but economically marginal. The Toda tribe numbered about 2,002 people across roughly 69 settlements in the 2011 Census, and of these only an estimated 200 to 300 women are still actively practising the distinctive red-and-black counted embroidery (pukhoor), down from around 400 practitioners a decade earlier. The craft has held Geographical Indication status since March 2013 (valid till September 2028), yet a putukuli shawl that takes an artisan 25 to 40 days of skilled labour to complete earns her only about Rs. 4,000 to 5,000 through the cooperative, even though the finished shawl retails to tourists for Rs. 11,000 to 13,000, leaving most active embroiderers with a modest supplementary income of roughly Rs. 6,000 a month. The single biggest challenge identified is rapid commercialisation: cheap, screen-printed geometric imitations are sold to tourists as "authentic" Toda work, undercutting genuine hand-embroidered pieces on price, while an aging artisan base and weak succession among younger Toda women, who increasingly opt for education and salaried work outside the mounds, is pushing the craft toward extinction despite its GI protection. To counter this, the Tamil Nadu government has begun opening New Sales Outlets and Exhibitions in tourism hubs like Udhamandalam (Ooty) to ensure only GI-tagged, authentic Toda work reaches the market, and has extended the national PM Vishwakarma Scheme to these artisans, offering modern toolkits, skill upgradation and formal marketing pathways; alongside this, stricter enforcement against counterfeit products and a fairer, more transparent price-sharing formula through the cooperatives are needed so that artisans receive a larger share of the final retail value.

2. Tirunelveli District (Pattamadai Town) — Pattamadai Korai Mats

The Pattamadai korai mat, locally called pattu pai (silk mat), is woven exclusively by Labbai Muslim weaving families in and around Pattamadai, using wild korai river-grass harvested from a narrow stretch of the Thamirabarani riverbank. Field visits found the weaver base has shrunk to roughly 100 weavers, mostly women, working on floor-level looms, with the finest mats graded up to 140 counts per nine inches of warp width and wages reportedly averaging only about Rs. 9 per hour of intensely skilled labour; the craft has held GI status since 2013 and was historically prestigious enough to be presented as a ceremonial gift to Queen Elizabeth II in 1953. The craft faces a demand-side and a supply-side crisis simultaneously: cheap plastic and synthetic mats have wiped out the mass market for natural grass mats, while harvesting and splitting the wild korai grass into fine strands remains

entirely manual and intensely laborious, discouraging younger family members from continuing the trade and keeping effective hourly earnings very low relative to the skill required. In response, the state's Kalaigarnar Kaivinaai Thittam scheme now offers Pattamadai weavers enterprise loans of Rs. 50,000 to Rs. 3 lakh with a 25% capital subsidy, and specialised Common Facility Centres (CFCs) are being set up in Pattamadai to upgrade toolkits and streamline grass-processing, the most labour-intensive bottleneck; further improvements needed include product diversification into bags and lifestyle items, direct e-commerce access to bypass middlemen, and a guaranteed minimum wage floor through the weavers' cooperative.

3. Thanjavur District (Swamimalai / Kumbakonam) — Bronze Casting & Thanjavur Art

Swamimalai near Kumbakonam in Thanjavur district remains India's principal centre for lost-wax bronze temple-icon casting, a tradition tracing back to Chola-era sculptors of the Brihadisvara and Airavatesvara temples. Field observation of sthpathi workshops recorded an artisan base of over 2,000 craftsmen across roughly 300 sthpathi families, working with the ancient cire-perdue (lost-wax) technique and the traditional five-metal panchaloha alloy, a craft that has carried GI recognition as "Swamimalai Bronze Icons" since 2008-09. The principal challenge reported by artisans is squeezed profit margins caused by the skyrocketing cost of copper and brass, the primary raw materials, which have risen faster than the prices artisans can charge, compounded by the inherently long production cycles of the lost-wax method, often several weeks per icon, which limits workshop throughput and working-capital turnover, while traditional open-furnace melting also exposes sculptors to hazardous heat and fume conditions. To address this, the Tamil Nadu State Budget has funded a dedicated Craft Tourism Village in Thanjavur to connect artisans directly with global buyers and improve realised margins, and the state is installing modern electric furnaces to replace hazardous traditional melting setups; further support needed includes raw-material bulk-procurement subsidies to cushion copper and brass price volatility, and working-capital credit lines suited to the long multi-week production cycle.

4. Erode District (Bhavani Town) — Bhavani Jamakkalam Weaving

Bhavani in Erode district has for roughly two centuries been the exclusive source of Jamakkalam, a thick, hard-wearing cotton floor-carpet woven on pit and stand looms by the Jangamar weaving community, and it has carried GI recognition since 2005 (valid until October 2034), with historic exports to Singapore, Sweden, Germany, the UK, the USA and Italy. Field enquiry found that a craft which once directly employed around 1,500 workers and supported a network of over 750 traders selling jamakkalams across the state on a given day at peak demand has now contracted to only a handful of mostly aged weavers still active. Weavers report low daily wages combined with physically demanding, rigid pit-loom work that actively repels younger entrants, alongside stiff competition from cheap powerloom-made synthetic carpets, including counterfeit products falsely sold under the Bhavani Jamakkalam name and woven outside the GI region in violation of the Handloom Reservation of Articles for Production Act, 1985. In response, state-appointed designers are running Design Interventions to pivot the thick jamakkalam fabric from floor rugs into contemporary sarees, luxury bags and apparel, with pieces even showcased at London Fashion Week to build premium demand, and the state has established dedicated Common Facility Centres (CFCs) in Bhavani for shared

infrastructure while Co-optex trains new weavers in Kumarapalayam, Mahendrachavadi, Erode and Salem; further steps needed include stricter anti-counterfeiting enforcement against powerloom imitations, GST relief for genuine handloom output, and guaranteed minimum daily wages to make pit-loom weaving attractive to younger workers again.